

Season Supply (6334-0): A Case for Raising the Budget

The Sound Department's annual **Season Supply** account has been funded at a flat **\$15,000** for at least four consecutive seasons. Over that period it has run over budget in three of four years, and this season's overage is roughly three to four times larger than any prior year. This report traces the spend by category across four seasons of records to show that the overage is not the result of loose spending, but of a single, unavoidable, recurring cost — wireless mic element replacement — that alone consumes the large majority of the account every year.

\$15,000 Season Supply budget (unchanged, 4+ seasons)	3 of 4 seasons ran over budget	72% of 3-season spend was mic elements/capsules alone	-\$4,663 this season's overage — the worst on record
--	--	--	---

What Season Supply Pays For

Season Supply (account 6334-0) is the department's shared consumables and small-repair budget, separate from each show's individual Materials – Sound line (5610). It covers items that keep the department's existing wireless and comms inventory running across every show in the season: wireless mic capsule (element) replacement, batteries, lav sweat protection sleeves, mic belts/pouches, cable and repair consumables, and occasional small equipment or short-term rentals. Unlike per-show budgets, it is not tied to any single production — it is fixed department overhead, and it has been set at \$15,000 without a documented review since at least the 22-23 season.

Four Seasons of Actuals

Season	Budget	Actual Spend	Remaining	Result
22-23	\$15,000.00	\$15,927.02	-\$927.02	Over
23-24	\$15,000.00	\$14,056.94	+\$943.06	Under (only year)
24-25	\$15,000.00	\$16,401.36	-\$1,401.36	Over
MS26 (current)	\$15,000.00	\$19,663.03	-\$4,663.03	Over — worst on record

Source: season budget tracker files (22-23, 23-24, 24-25 *Sound budget tracking.xlsx*, archived 2026-07-06) and the live MS26 Google Sheet. Figures are each tab's own Total/Remaining row, not a manual re-sum. Average actual spend across all four seasons is **\$16,512/year** — already above the \$15,000 budget — and the trend line is accelerating, not flat: the overage roughly doubles or worse in each successive over-budget year.

Where the Money Actually Goes

Categorizing every line item across the three fully-archived seasons (22-23, 23-24, 24-25 — \$46,385.32 in total spend) shows one category dominates every single year:

Category	22-23	23-24	24-25	3-Season Total	% of Total
Mic elements/capsules	\$11,425.60	\$10,583.07	\$11,478.68	\$33,487.35	72.2%
Other consumables/misc	\$743.38	\$599.86	\$1,802.21	\$3,145.45	6.8%
Repairs/service	\$0.00	\$895.13	\$1,527.86	\$2,422.99	5.2%

Category	22-23	23-24	24-25	3-Season Total	% of Total
Computers/electronics	\$2,170.91	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$2,170.91	4.7%
Lav sweat protection	\$345.00	\$920.00	\$460.00	\$1,725.00	3.7%
Batteries	\$0.00	\$412.33	\$849.11	\$1,261.44	2.7%
Unattributed line item	\$829.25	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$829.25	1.8%
Mic belts/pouches	\$157.12	\$244.39	\$0.00	\$401.51	0.9%
Rentals	\$162.90	\$0.00	\$217.20	\$380.10	0.8%
Show-control equipment	\$0.00	\$373.30	\$0.00	\$373.30	0.8%
Office/misc supplies	\$92.86	\$28.86	\$45.96	\$167.68	0.4%
Repair shipping	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$20.34	\$20.34	0.0%

Mic element/capsule replacement (Shure and Countryman B6 elements, purchased through Sweetwater and Countryman directly) averaged **\$11,162 per season** — 74% of the entire \$15,000 budget — in every one of the three archived seasons, with almost no year-to-year variance (\$10.6k-\$11.5k range). This is not a one-time or discretionary purchase; it is the direct, recurring cost of keeping a rep-season wireless mic inventory functional under nightly use. Every other category combined — batteries, sweat protection, belts, repairs, rentals, office supplies — has to fit inside the remaining ~26% of the budget (roughly \$3,500-4,000/year). That is why the account tips into deficit in most seasons even without any unusual or one-off spending.

This Season's Larger Overage

MS26's Season Supply overage (-\$4,663.03) is three to five times any archived season's overage. The live sheet's own itemization shows why: this season carries the same underlying mic-element cost as every prior year (Sweetwater \$4,982 split receipt for 14 elements + Countryman B6 \$1,827 ≈ \$6,809, actually below the 3-season average) plus two cost categories that don't appear in the archive at all:

MS26 item	Amount	Category
3× Allen & Heath ME-1 personal mixers	\$2,615.00	Equipment purchase (not a consumable)
Apex Consulting — RF interference resolution (2 invoices)	\$3,900.00	Professional services (new cost type)
Mic batteries (2× \$1,494.67)	\$2,989.34	Recurring, consistent with prior seasons

The ME-1 purchase and the RF consulting engagement together total **\$6,515** — more than this season's entire overage. Both are legitimate, one-time-per-need costs (equipment expansion and an RF spectrum problem that needed outside expertise), but neither is a "consumable" in the sense the \$15,000 figure was presumably set around. Two things are true at once: the underlying consumable cost (mic elements, batteries) keeps climbing toward the top of the historical range, and the department is increasingly being asked to absorb non-consumable costs — equipment and outside services — out of the same fixed pool.

The Ask

Raise Season Supply (6334-0) from \$15,000 to \$20,000 for MS27 and beyond.

That figure is not an arbitrary round number — it is close to what the department has actually needed in its worst recent year (\$19,663.03, MS26) and gives roughly \$8,500 of headroom over the proven, recurring mic-element cost floor

(~\$11,200/season) for batteries, repairs, sweat protection, belts, and the occasional equipment or consulting need that MS26 shows is becoming more common, not less. At the current flat \$15,000, the department is structurally under-resourced for its own known, recurring cost floor before a single battery or repair is purchased.

Supporting factors:

- **Mic element cost is structural, not discretionary.** It has consumed 70-76% of the \$15,000 budget in every one of the last three fully-closed seasons with almost no variance — this is the baseline cost of running the department's wireless inventory, not a spike to manage down.
- **The current lav mics (Countryman B6) are already flagged internally as a driver of this cost.** A separate donor-funded upgrade proposal (Countryman B6 → DPA 4061 CORE) cites fragile cables, sweat-induced crackling, and unit-to-unit inconsistency forcing re-EQ every soundcheck as the reasons the current lavs need replacing — the same wear pattern driving the mic-element repurchases in this report. Until that capital upgrade happens (if it happens), Season Supply will keep absorbing this cost at the current rate or higher.
- **The trend is worsening, not stabilizing.** Overage went from -\$927 (22-23) to +\$943 under (23-24) to -\$1,401 (24-25) to -\$4,663 (MS26) — a season-over-season pattern that, if it continues, will not self-correct at the current budget level.
- **A higher ceiling also creates room to separate cost types going forward.** Alongside the increase, the department recommends tracking one-time equipment purchases (e.g. the ME-1 mixers) and outside professional services (e.g. RF consulting) as a distinct sub-line within Season Supply or against a capital line, so future budget conversations can distinguish routine consumable cost from occasional equipment/service spend rather than treating both as the same kind of overage.

Sources: Season budget tracker files (22-23, 23-24, 24-25 Sound budget tracking.xlsx; archived 2026-07-06 to Raw/AUD-IT/Budget/Past Seasons/) and the live MS26 “(E) Sound budget tracking” Google Sheet (Season Supply tab, pulled 2026-07-03/07-06). Full per-season tables and category detail are also maintained in the department's internal Wiki (Sound Budget Tracking page). Historical totals have not been cross-checked against finance/accounting records outside these tracker files.